

PLOT SUMMARY

In an abandoned library, three bugs learn to read the books they were tasked to destroy. The teens secretly meet in their book club to share their findings on human culture and the outside world. Their soon-to-be member stumbles upon a pest control booklet, making them ask whether humanity should be remembered.

Turner is a worldly cockroach nymph who founded the Book Club to record books their parents tasked them to destroy. The two other longtime members are Ear, a musically inclined beetle larva, and Luke, a moth caterpillar who is the textbook definition of boring. Bark is the new kid hoping to join as their booklouse nymph.

Before Bark's trial, they search for the perfect book to share with the help of a jumpy bacterium named Germ. They find a book titled *The Audience*. They bury their head in this book.

In the book club, all share their findings. However, Bark's discovery left most unmoved. Bark is not yet welcomed in the Secret Library, but is given another chance to read more. They seek literature in the library's backroom, patrolled by the Tailless Scorpion. There, they find a booklet titled *How to Put Bookworms on Hold*. When Tailless awakens, Bark escapes.

Bark returns with no story. The book club rejects Bark, but Turner still hangs out with Bark. Soon, the library's figurehead, known as the Firebrat, visits to check on the decomposition process and give a state of the library speech. Inspired, Bark goes to the book club with three books containing anti-human sentiments. The three are not persuaded, but now welcome Bark. However, Bark had the Firebrat watch them secretly from afar. The Book Club is detained, and the Secret Library is torn down.

In the following act, the three are locked up under a jar. The Firebrat holds Bark to a high esteem. They have Bark lead the demolition of the history aisle. There, Bark notes child labor and notices that bugs and humans are not so different. Feeling guilty for their betrayal, Bark offers themselves up to Tailless. Tailless welcomes Bark in their mouth, so Bark can understand why they protect books. A while ago, Turner faced Tailless and had that same realization after a life of destroying books.

Bark returns to free the book club. The Firebrat's swarm chases them until bacteria take them down. The Firebrat catches Turner, ready to end them, but Bark sprays the Firebrat with pesticide, having learnt from the booklet. Blinded, the Firebrat ends up in Tailless's claws. The Book Club members hide in *The Audience*.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

BARK, booklouse nymph, a kid and Book Club hopeful who reads

TURNER, cockroach nymph, a campy teen who reads field guides

EAR, beetle larva, a poetic teen who reads sheet music

LUKE, moth caterpillar, a toneless teen who reads textbooks

THE **FIREBRAT**, firebrat, an adult supervising the library

JEREMY GERALD **GERMAIN** THE GREAT, bacterium, a bug's bug

THE **TAILLESS** SCORPION, pseudoscorpion, a bug's shadow monster

Ensemble

BUGS, bugs from Firebrat's swarm portrayed as stick puppets

BACTERIA, bug's bugs portrayed as laser pointers' dots

○ Androgyny Entomology: Each character resembles the androgynous nature, so each role is gender inclusive

○ People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of this communal swarm; cast accordingly